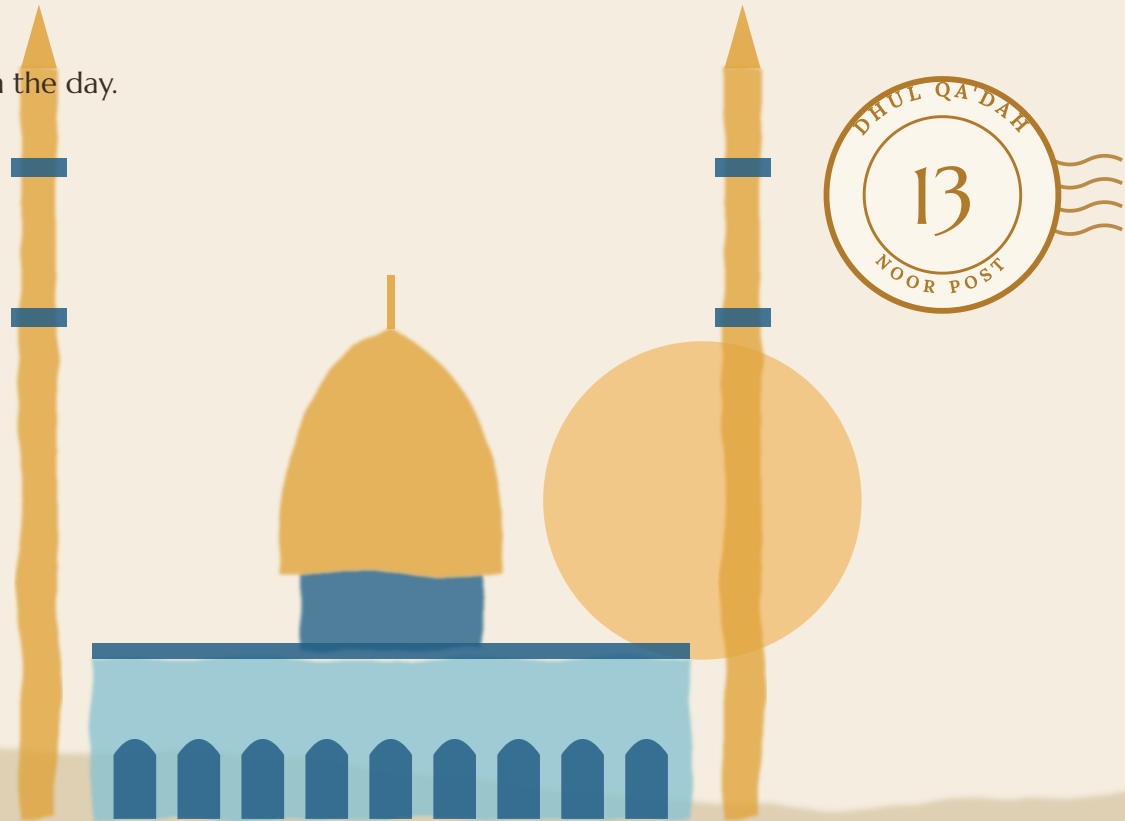


NOOR POST

One of fourteen. Open it on the day.



FOR

[Child's name]



Noor Post

[Return address — not set]

ENVELOPE 13 · DHUL
QA'DAH · INSIDE THE FLAP

Open together.

🕒 **About twenty-five minutes**

● is the grown-up. ○ is you.

- 1 The letter — read it out loud, ● and ○ taking turns
- 2 The hadith card
- 3 The prints
- 4 Talk about it
- 5 The stickers
- 6 The postcard

FACT PANEL

Imam Ali al-Rida

(peace be upon him)

B. 148 AH, MEDINA · D. 203 AH, TUS

- **Where and when.** Medina, and then a journey across the whole empire to Khurasan in the far northeast, which he did not come back from. He is buried at Tus, in the city now called Mashhad — a word that means the place where someone was witnessed.
- **Who was ruling.** The Abbasid caliph al-Ma'mun, from Merv and later Baghdad — a ruler who collected scholars, funded translation, and staged public debates for entertainment.
- **The imamate.** About twenty years, from 183 AH, from the age of about thirty-five.
- **What he left.** Recorded debates. Al-Ma'mun put him in front of scholars of other religions — Christian, Jewish, Zoroastrian — in front of an audience, more than once, and the exchanges were written down. **This is the best-documented of the fourteen for a plain reason: the government wanted a record.**
- **Sayyida Masuma.** His sister. She set out from Medina to reach him in Khurasan, got as far as Qom, and died there. The city grew around where she was buried, and it is a place of study now because of a journey that did not arrive.
- **Elsewhere in the world.** In the same years, Norse ships had begun arriving on the coasts of Britain and Ireland, and the monasteries there were starting to move their books inland.

He died at Tus in 203 AH, far from Medina, on the journey al-Ma'mun had summoned him on. Shia accounts hold that he was killed on the orders of al-Ma'mun.

ENVELOPE 13 · DHUL QA'DAH

The Job He Would Not Do



● is the grown-up · ○ is you · ●○ is together

- A letter arrived in Medina from the other end of the empire. It was from the caliph, and it was not a request. He was to travel to Khurasan — about two thousand miles, months of it — and he was not being told why.

○ Did he have to go?

- You do not say no to that letter. He went. He left his family behind, and the accounts say he did not expect to come back, and he said so before he left.

○ What did the caliph want?

- This is the strange part. When he arrived, al-Ma'mun offered him the empire.

○ The whole thing?

- First the throne itself, and then, when that was refused, the next best thing: crown prince. Named heir. Next in line to rule everything from Egypt to the edge of India. In public, on the coins, in the Friday sermon.

○ Why would he do that?

- Because his own family had spent a hundred and fifty years fighting this one, and this ended it in an afternoon and made him look generous while doing it. Nobody gives away an empire. He was buying something.

○ So did he say yes?

- He said yes to the title. Then he set out his conditions, and here they are. He would appoint nobody. He would dismiss nobody. He would not change a single thing that was already in place. And he would not give an opinion on any decision unless he was asked for one.

○ That's a job with no job in it.

- He took the title and refused the work. Which meant he could not be blamed for anything the government did, and could not be used to sign off on any of it, and everyone in that court knew exactly why.

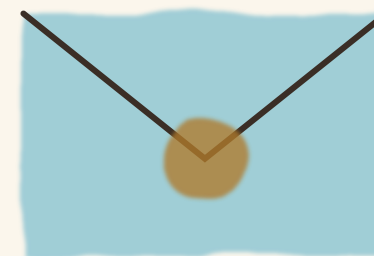
○ Would you have taken it? Say yes or no before we go on.

- He wore the clothes and he stood where they told him to stand, and for the rest of it he did what he had done in Medina, which was answer questions from anybody who asked one.

SAY THIS ONE TOGETHER

●○

He took the name. He
would not take the job.



Then the hadith card.

IMAM AL-RIDA SAID

“Silence is one of the doors of wisdom. It yields amicability and leads to every goodness.”

Imam al-Rida

NOOR POST · THE FOURTEEN

The chain

Every card in this box is one link. Lay all fourteen in order and the chain runs from the Prophet to the last of the twelve, each one passing on what was given.



Fourteen segments · historical order

Tuhaf al-Uqul, short maxims, no. 8. Translated by Badr Shahin,
Ansariyan Publications, Qum.

Talk about it

About ten minutes. No right answers, and no points.

2

• Grown-up answers this one first.

Tell about a time you were offered something good that had a catch in it. Did you spot the catch?

3

The caliph got to look generous. What did he actually want in return?

TURN OVER →

TALK ABOUT IT · CONTINUED

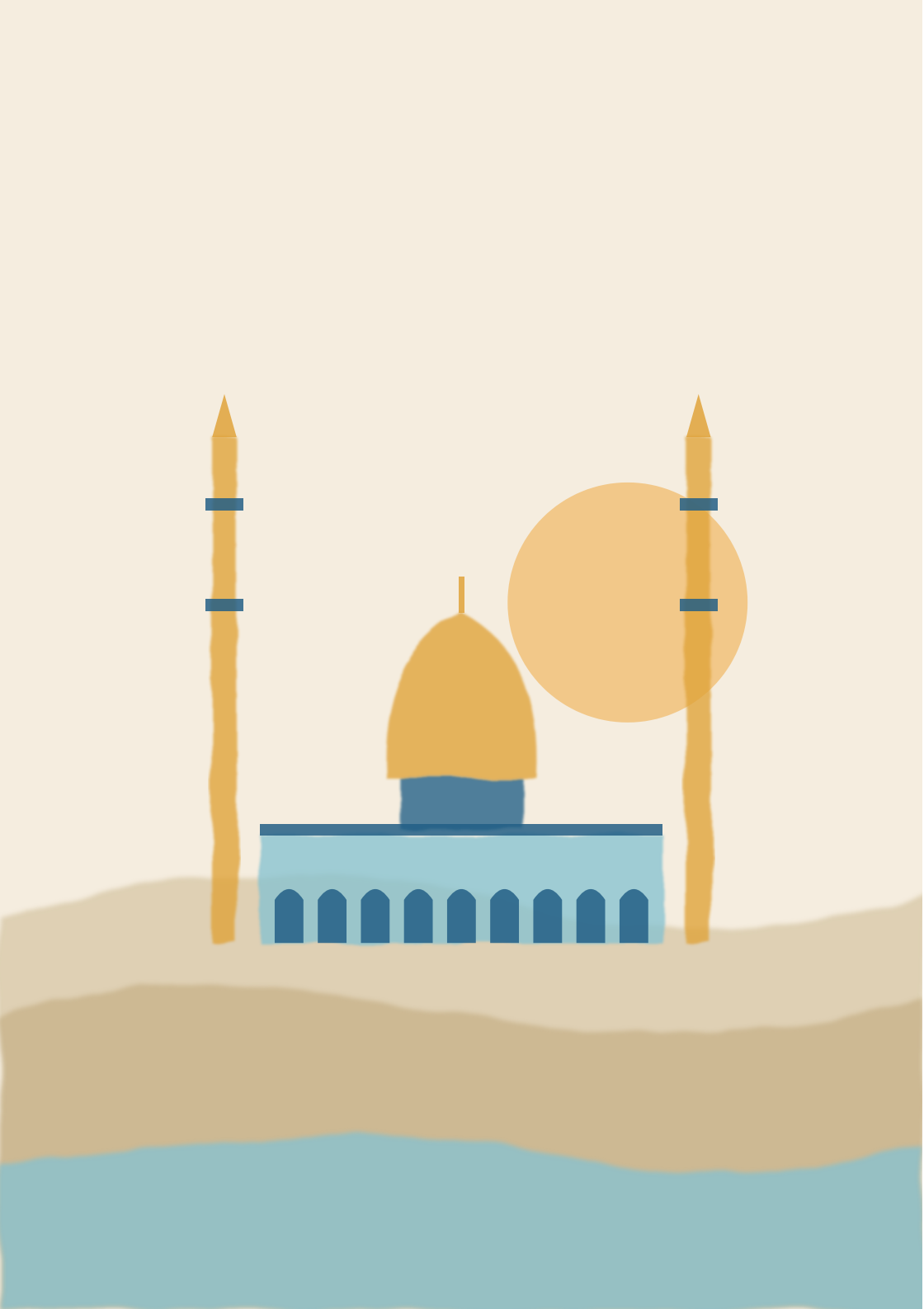
4 His sister set out to reach him and never got there, and a whole city grew where she stopped. Does that count as arriving?

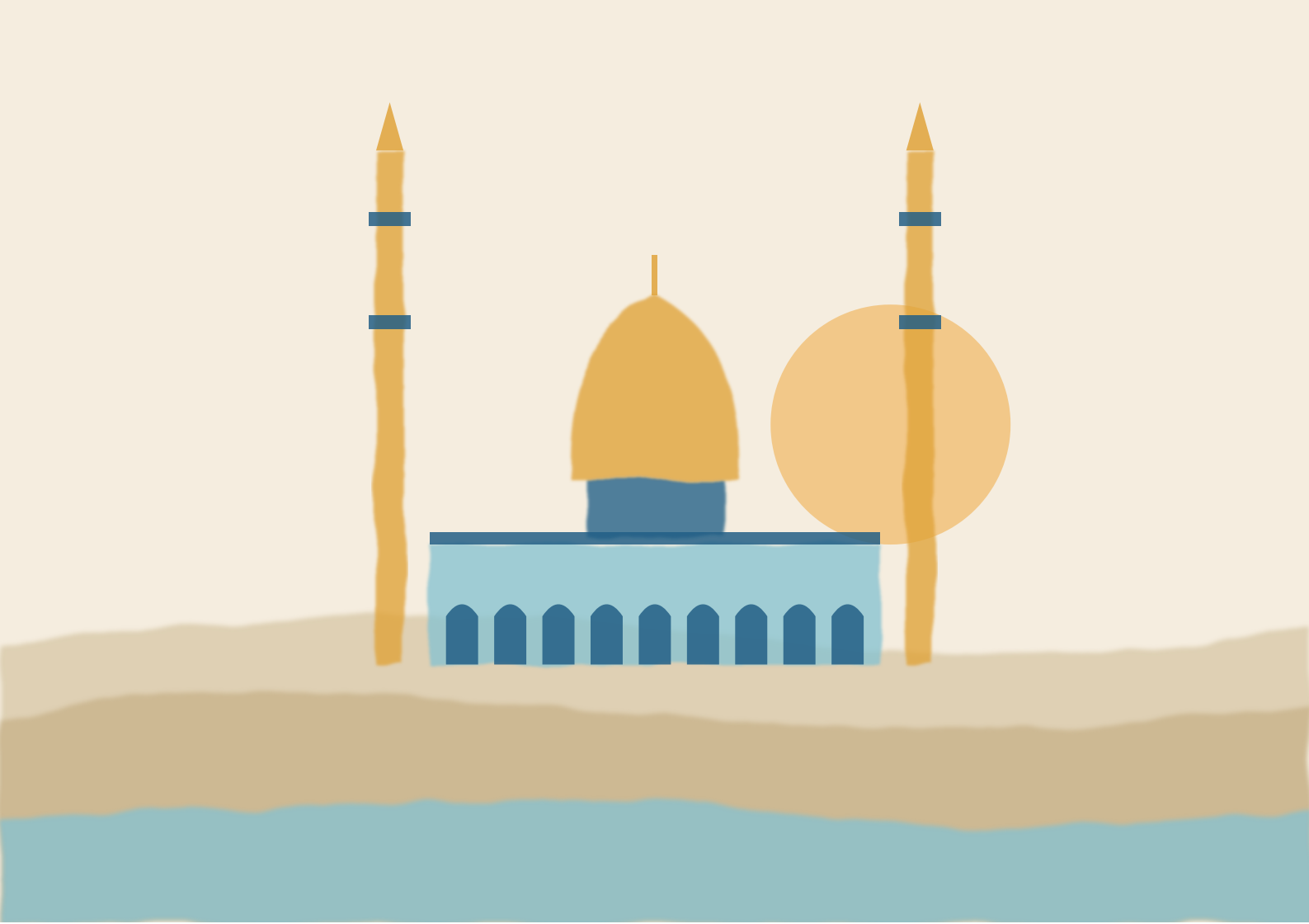
5 **► This one is hard for a grown-up.**

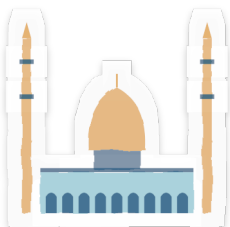
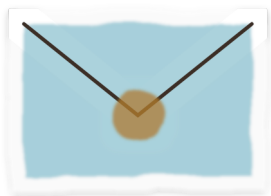
He agreed to appoint nobody, so he could never be blamed for anything. Is refusing to decide a way of staying clean, or a way of hiding?

LAST

One of you names a job in this house. The other one says what conditions they would attach before taking it. Then swap.









We opened this one
together.

● _____

○ _____

Post it back to us, or keep it. Either is right.



Noor Post

[Return address — not set]
